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Ethos in Engineering Building II

Despite feeling excluded during the lobby's busy hours, the lobby is designed to encourage collaboration. The many round tables force people to look and engage with one another. The openness of the lobby ensures you are not hidden. The study area invites every person passing by to join in at a table and get some work done. The space naturally creates the identity of working hard and collaboration of those who use the space. The identity a space creates for those who experience it creates or destroys one's sense of belonging in it by displaying who has been in the building and what others currently in it are also doing.

Upon entering the space, you instantly understand what it is you are meant to do in the space. When I entered the space to take pictures for this assignment, I immediately understood the lobby was not a place for casual loitering. Every person at a table had an assignment or project in front of them and were actively engaged in it with the people around them.

During the Knight Hacks event, the space told a completely different story. The space was not being used for studying or group collaboration, the space, in that moment, was meant to be used to allow mentees meet mentors. With just a quick scan of a room, one can instantly understand what is acceptable in the space.

This is known as ethos. Downs describes how we recognize ethos by stating "He suggested that rhetors get a sense of each others' ethos in three ways: by assessing their expertise, their moral character, and their goodwill toward other rhetors – their willingness to put others' interest first" (page 475) Although the lobby is designed to encourage group collaboration, the exact actions that are acceptable in a space are often determined by how others are currently using the space. In this way, those who use the space become the rhetors of the space in that moment.